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Repossessing the Self in the Collective:
Body, Language and the Voice in Fanon

> *"When I sing this thing, I remember seeing David for the last time as he rode away with the Feds with his hands cuffed, and the big, glowerky 'Resist the Draft' sticker on the bumper which the Resistance had put on while they were arresting him…"*
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> — Joan Baez
> Prelude to 'We Shall Overcome'
> Carry It On (1971)

In his seminal works 'Black Skin, White Masks' and 'The Wretched of the Earth', Frantz Fanon grapples with questions of colonization, race, history and identity through the motifs of body and language. For Fanon, a phenomenologist, the body is the site of consciousness and hence every experience of reality, by definition, is radically embodied. He sees language as a symptom of the colonial disease: the universalizing power of language is built upon racialized structures, and so even the mere use of language is reflective of a white hegemony. Across his works, he grapples with the alienation of the coloured man in both body and language as a result of white colonization.

In 'Black Skin, White Masks', the body and the voice detach from each other in the face of the overwhelming history of white superiority – Fanon leaves us there with a gaping void in place of an answer to his haunting question, "Where should I stick myself? […] Where should I hide?" (81). A decade later, in 'The Wretched of the Earth', he answers himself, "[…] in the people's struggle against the forces of occupation" (159), where the voice finds itself with the sea of bodies fighting for freedom. In this essay, I will attempt to sketch out the figure of the black man, alienated from the white world, as Fanon portrays him in Chapter Five of 'Black Skin, White Masks', *The Lived Experience of the Black Man*; then, I set out to show that Fanon reconciles this alienation by positing

the revival of an authentic culture that the black man belongs to, through Chapter Four of 'The Wretched of the Earth', *On National Culture*.

The Black Man, Dispossessed

The very first sentence Fanon writes about *The Lived Experience of the Black Man* is ""Dirty nigger!" Or simply, "Look, a Negro!"" (78). Further in the essay, he outlines an incident he experiences on a train, presumably during an everyday commute, where a white child points to him and exclaims, thrice: "Look, a Negro!". Within this short exclamation, Fanon elegantly presents a simple fact: the black man must always answer to an account of history written into his skin. The power of this white child's gaze recurses and reduces him to a historicity assigned to him by white narrative: the word 'Negro' is not a reference to an individual's blackness, but it refers to his race's ancestry of supposed "cannibalism, backwardness, fetishism" (80).

Every person has the phenomenological experience of being spatiotemporally located, what Fanon refers to as a "body schema" – but in the case of the black man, this body schema is underwritten by a "historical-racial schema", something that he constructs himself in encountering the white perception of the black man (79). The child, with one exclamation, bypasses his body schema and flays open an "epidermal" historical-racial schema, multiplying the damning awareness of his race with each iteration of the exclamation; he becomes "no longer in third person, but in triple" (80). Here, the White gaze takes away from the black man his selfhood by collapsing his body schema, it "objectively cut[s] sections of [his] reality" (83). In this sense, the very being of a black man is characterised by a void – he has "no ontological resistance in the eyes of the white man" (78), his only ontology is alienation.

The shocking, traumatic force of the exclamation – "Look, a Negro!" – disembodies, and hence depersonalizes and dispossesses, the black man. And this dispossession shows itself as a deep and nauseating shame that takes over and belies any language – there are no words available to wield in French, the language of the colonizer. There is an urge to laugh, to commit an action outside of language, but that too is suppressed: "I wanted to kill myself laughing, but laughter had become out of the question" (80). Within the space of his silence, the black man, stripped of his selfhood and drowning in his blackness, becomes hypervisible as an (black) object. The white mother claims this

silence by further hypervisibilizing him: “Look how handsome that Negro is” (82). In this instance, the black man finally finds his language, he snaps back, “This Negro says ‘Fuck you’, madame”[1] (82). The crassness of this language lends itself to a violence against the white mother and, for a moment, the body and voice that separated from each other under the child’s gaze *reunite* in this forceful return.

But this moment of freedom, this sharpening of his incisors, doesn’t last – the white world “denies [him] the slightest recognition” (82). The black man is robbed of his body and his voice anew: evident stylistically in the myriad of texts Fanon intersperses the rest of his essay with, we realize that no single voice is enough to fully express the subjugation of the black man under the white gaze. The question of where the black man goes, his ontological existence, will always be a negation. The dispossession of his body and self is beyond language – Fanon, too, leaves us only with the figure of a black man weeping toward the open sky (101).

Repossessing the Black Self

So far, I have posited that Fanon, in ‘Black Skin, White Masks’, portrays the black man as having a gaping hole in place of belonging – further, his alienation from the white world separates the body and the voice, outside of a singular moment of violence against the white woman. Rediscovering this freedom again seems impossible, Fanon loses it on re-encountering the white world. The question of where the black man finds his own history and ontology, away from the white gaze that “distorts it, disfigures it and destroys it” (149), remains. In ‘The Wretched of the Earth’, he draws a map to it: the black man’s body and voice again coalesce in violence – but this time, on a collective scale through the struggle for national freedom, the voice cannot be lost.

He overwrites the epidermal racial-historical schema in the act of joining the ranks of a national revolution. The desire for a black history is decimated in the face of urgent concerns of a budding nation-state: its “geographical position and economic interdependence” takes precedence (154). The need for a black history to fall back on, which is itself steeped into the desire for validation in the white gaze, is completely destroyed. Through a reversion to their own people, the black men let

[1] “This Negro says, ‘Kiss my ass’, madame,” in other translations.

go of the false universalism of white culture by renouncing the dichotomy the white language indoctrinated them into – "the entire system loses its bearings" (158). He stitches back the body's selfhood through violence, by a radical embracing of the shame written onto himself and his brothers: "rediscovering one's people means […] going as native as possible, becoming unrecognizable" (158). He reclaims the word – "Look, a Negro!" is no longer a dissection of his identity, but an assertion. Violence is not only implied, but central to this act, precisely because it is by definition embodied: the violence enacted onto the white mother with his crass language multiplies on a national scale. It is not possible to strip the black man of his body schema in such a militant claim for autonomy.

There is no more searching for where to 'stick' oneself – the black people defeat the orthodox stability of the white world by creating their own "zone of hidden fluctuation" (163). The child's white gaze loses its power to dispossess black selfhood when it can no longer shame the black man for the histories it created. When the black man refuses to answer to the demands for a 'civilized' culture that the white gaze impresses upon him, and instead reunites with his people in the fight for freedom, he reconciles his body with his voice – amplified through his brothers' cries for freedom, freedom, freedom.

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References

Fanon, Frantz. *Black Skin, White Masks*. Grove Press, 1967.

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